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ZewelANJI N. Serpell

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Supporting the integration of evidence into federal educational policy and reform efforts: A navigational framework for educational researchers

Zewelanjji N. Serpell

Department of Psychology, Virginia Commonwealth University

ABSTRACT

There is an ongoing debate about how best to infuse “evidence” into school evaluation and reform efforts, and what role education researchers can play in this effort. A lot of support has been garnered for evidence-based reform or policies that place a premium on practices that have been proven effective using rigorous research methods; most often randomized controlled trials (RCTs). This article discusses challenges with these approaches in the policy space, and presents an alternative framework for educational researchers; one that requires a deeper and more strategic engagement in the policymaking process. It highlights that inherent in the federal process are important windows of opportunity for educational researchers to make their work count. The article considers the unique way in which time, intermediary partners, and communication influence the development of federal educational policy, and what the implications are for educational research.

There is enormous potential for policy decisions to be better informed by evidence, but the research-to-policy divide in American education is a vast chasm. This was the impression I had as an academic doing school-based research with little to no knowledge about policymaking; and this was what I came to know again, after a year of working in the political sphere as a congressional fellow. When I started outlining this article, it was my intention to articulate my insights about the root of this chasm based on my education policymaking experiences as a congressional fellow serving on the House Committee on Education and the Workforce. However, as I read more about this divide, I was astounded to discover that my specific “lessons learned” had already been articulated in papers as early as the 1970s (see for example Weiss, 1977). This fact, led me to a simple conclusion: this was a problem of translation. Educational researchers can concentrate their efforts on improving the evidence base for policy and practice decisions. However, these efforts may be rendered void because uptake is threatened by constraints embedded in the standards we set for our research to be considered valid, and by our inadequate engagement in the policymaking process.

In this article, I argue that in many ways the federal policymaking process can and does accommodate evidence, but how we define evidence matters. Adopting the gold-standard definition of “evidence” requires randomized controlled trial studies (RCTs; Slavin, 2017). However, the bottom line is that in politics, an RCT-based approach is not nimble enough to accommodate the complexity of the education field, nor the policymaking process as it is

currently structured in the United States (Finnigan & Daly, 2014). Further, educational policy is on the whole value-based (K. Wentzel, personal communication, April 2018), and is frequently driven by personal accounts of issues that emerge and inspire action in real-time. As such, successful contributions to policymaking are contingent on educational researchers being ready to engage with the right people, with the right information, at the right time (Weiss, 1991). The analysis presented here is in large part premised on the notion that to effectively put forward evidence you have to understand—and maybe even live in—the world of your intended recipients (Finnigan & Daly, 2014). The sections that follow describe this policymaking context, including its narrow domain of influence, and the structures in place therein, that define in what ways and when researchers can bring their evidence to bear.

The federal policymaking landscape then and now

The federal policymaking landscape can be viewed in terms of opportunities and constraints for educational researchers to indirectly and directly impact school improvement efforts. Historically in the United States, the federal government’s role in education has been limited. This is due to the tenth amendment, which defines federalism as a two-tiered system whereby a territory is controlled by two levels of governance—the federal government and the state (Nolan et al., 2018). Within the education arena, the tenth amendment also relegates most policy decisions to the states. As such, much of education policy pertinent to school evaluation and

reform is decided and implemented at state and local levels. For example, the federal government does not oversee decisions about curricula, teaching methods, instructional materials, nor even establish requirements or benchmarks for achievement.

Two key pieces of education legislation were signed into law in 1965: the Elementary and Secondary Education Act (ESEA) and the Higher Education Act (HEA). Since the 1960s, federal involvement has progressively grown, as indexed by the establishment of the Department of Education as an independent cabinet-level department in 1980 (U.S. Department of Education, 2015). Although, this department's role in policy remains relatively small. The primary mechanism through which the federal government plays a role in education is through its relations with the states, and more specifically through stipulations for funding allocations. "Evidence" entered federal education policy with ESEA, which laid the foundation for an emphasis on high standards and accountability, with funds authorized to support professional development and parental involvement, but also for instructional materials and educational program resources.

The first truly reform-minded federal policy approach emerged under president George Bush with the passing in 2001 of the No Child Left Behind Act (NCLB), and with this, "scientifically based research" was written into law (Peterson, 2016). It is important to note that while the infusion of an "evidence" mandate was certainly a positive shift in the policy world, things can go shockingly awry. A case in point with NCLB: student performance as assessed by standardized test scores were yoked to teacher evaluations, which had the tragic effect in some states of teachers "teaching to the test" or outright cheating (Croft, Roberts, & Stenhouse, 2015). A little over a decade later, ESEA was reauthorized under president Barack Obama as The Every Student Succeeds Act (ESSA) in 2015 and—in part in response to problems like the above—made dramatic changes to how school performance is measured, including requiring a comprehensive approach with multiple measures; defining and rewarding the use of evidence in policy and practice; and shifting many of the nuanced decisions around these back to the states (Skinner, 2019). Of note, both NCLB and ESSA are mostly regulatory policy approaches.

The distinction between a regulatory and other policy approaches is an important one as each approach yields a different policy structure. For example, I paraphrase below—in education terms—the difference between a regulatory approach and a developmental approach articulated in a chapter by Russel et al. (2018) regarding policy to support adapting to climate change. A regulatory approach aims at establishing a framework for action that is mandated, such that the goal is to create a stable regulatory environment in which actions can be monitored and corrected. This approach should result in a system that reduces cost and waste of taxpayers' money. Theoretically, it should also promote investment by inspiring confidence in efforts supported by and reflecting the federal policy mandate. For example, in educational reform efforts increased state

investment in education may be motivated or inspired by allocations from federal government that supports a particular type of school reform effort.

A developmental approach works to integrate policies within a dynamic context of ongoing change. Policies are therefore designed to facilitate rather than regulate, and to foster the creation and deployment of novel practices that support positive change. This policy approach is set up to stimulate work that can be adapted to push specific solutions that emerge out of local concerns. For example, language is included in policy that "encourages" some action, such as the evaluation of programs, but does not specify how this is done. Evidence plays a role in both regulatory and developmental policy approaches, but in the latter, evidence is not considered the only or most important factor and attention to the context of policymaking, including human factors is critical (Sutcliffe & Court, 2005). In the following sections, I focus on the role of evidence in the policymaking process.

Evidence in policymaking

In policymaking, there is preexisting evidence that can help inform policy decisions, and post-policy enactment evidence, which is evaluative and speaks to the impact of an existing policy. The key questions here are: what counts as evidence? When and why does evidence influence policy or not? For educational researchers, the question of evidence is really about data: what kind we pursue and how we go about collecting it (research methods). In the policy world, very careful attention is paid to how federally-owned data is made available, to who and for how long. In fact, data collection can itself be a policy issue. In 2017, for example, an effort was launched in congress to end a policy that mandated the collection of student achievement data disaggregated by race. The argument was that it served no purpose, even though its inclusion in policy was specifically to ensure schools recognized and could take steps to address achievement gaps.

Legislators also vary in their embrace of evidence arising from science-based research despite the fact that it is the defining feature of the two most significant policy shifts in education: the No Child Left Behind Act (2001) and the Every Student Succeeds Act (2015). Ambiguity about how to define "evidence" is related in part to ambivalence about what constitutes a fact (Schultz, 2017). This is important because "fact gathering" is the cornerstone of policymaking. How politicians and researchers view the world and how they gather facts to build evidence is very different. For politicians the gathering of facts is based on what will be most persuasive with the general public or with those whom they are trying to convince. In other words what will "sell" or be compelling to sway a majority of people and do so quickly. As such, the methods educational researchers adopt and tout as the gold standard, often fall short in policymaking contexts. Empirical studies take time, they rarely yield clear-cut answers, and evidence is mixed at best, contradictory at worst, and the educational researcher's solution to these

problems is to gather more data/conduct more studies (Horton & Brown, 2018). Yet, time is perhaps the one thing that politicians do not have more to waste.

Even so, this past decade has seen a growing push toward adopting an evidence-based approach to educational policy and practice. This approach posits that for policy to count as evidence-based it must have as its root data derived from studies that adopt a scientific methodological approach, and ideally, randomized controlled trials (RCTs). This has commandeered a massive increase in the use of RCTs in education research (Connolly, Keenan, & Urbanska, 2018). The RCT approach is not, however, universally embraced in the context of educational policymaking and very specific concerns have been raised (Morrison, 2001; Styles & Torgerson, 2018). However, a couple of key points are worth mentioning about the drawbacks of an RCT-based approach to infusing evidence into policymaking.

First, RCT research cannot actually provide definitive answers to the complex education problems we are trying to solve through policy (Lortie-Forgues & Inglis, 2019). Raudenbush (2015) articulates this challenge well: “Does the answer to a precisely focused research question, by itself, have implications for practical action? What happens when ‘other things’ are not held constant? For example, if we give school district leaders the authority to base personnel decisions on value added or other measures of teacher effectiveness, will we undermine the authority of the school principal?” Hence, even perfectly executed RCTs may not translate into policies that make sense (Hess, 2008). Furthermore, often what works is context-specific, such that rarely are we able to replicate proven effects (Nutley, Davies, & Walter, 2002). A study by Dynarski et al. (2007) is a case in point. Their RCT testing the impact of instructional software showed positive effects in some schools and negative effects in others, and effects were correlated with some classroom and school characteristics (e.g., student-teacher ratio).

In addition, what is particularly challenging for bridging the research to policy divide is that our science-based discovery process simply takes too long. Confidence that a given educational intervention works is built over the course of several years—sometimes almost a decade, and often long after the evidence is needed to inform policy decisions. One might consider, for example, if the RCT approach will also inevitably fail to keep up with technological advances because by the time one technology has been sufficiently tested, the technology in question may be obsolete. The policy world is decidedly more urgent, partly because it is prompted by an event or set of circumstances that is personal and critical.

The aforementioned limitations notwithstanding, policymakers have become much more amenable to and in fact demand evidence. As such, research increasingly matters and holds particular sway with policymakers. A clear index of this is the recent passing of the Foundations for Evidence-Based Policymaking Act of 2019, which prompts significant government-wide reforms to make data more accessible and sets the stage for data to be more useful in policy-related decision-making. Prioritized within this piece

of legislation is open data—making non-sensitive government data electronically accessible to the public, and ensuring user-friendly formats and confidentiality. As such, while educational researchers might not agree on the “best evidence,” we can all agree that evidence should most certainly play a role in policymaking. Further, we will now have access to federally-owned data that can be securely analyzed to answer important questions and can inform educational policymaking. We also get closer to being able to make our science count in policymaking if we do not expect for the policymaking process to mimic the scientific discovery process (Horton & Brown, 2018). We can be better contributors if we focus squarely on employing systematic approaches, but recognize the limitations of any particular method (Haskins & Baron, 2011). Policy should be informed by a wide breadth of evidence and methodologies, not just RCTs. RCTs may be the gold standard for our judgement about what constitutes good evidence in our field of research, but in the broader field of educational policy, being relevant and timely may outweigh the need to select this particular methodological approach. This does not obfuscate the importance or need for RCTs, it just avoids making them the most important thing.

The policymaking chronosystem: Timeframes, timeliness, and timing

There are arguably few real incentives for the use of educational research in politics (Wong, 2008), primarily because the timeframe for research to generate evidence and that of political decision-making are misaligned. Borrowing from Bronfenbrenner’s and Ceci (1994) theory about human development, policy development does not happen in a vacuum and has a particular chronosystem or a set of changing conditions determined by sociohistorical circumstance and environmental events that emerge over the life course and prompt change. Applying this notion of a chronosystem to think about policymaking highlights that there is both stability and change in policy, and that many factors across both historical time and cultural space interact to influence its development.

The federal education policymaking process is often activated by a salient event that occurs in a particular cultural context at a particular point in time, like a school shooting (Sandy Hook) or a catastrophic weather event (Hurricane Katrina). There is a lot of pressure to act and do so quickly (Oakley, Pesta, Ciftci, & Blomberg, 2013) and it is not infrequent that within hours a legislator will decide their position on an issue and announce it. The public statement renders the position something to which the legislator will forever be held. Delaying a response or back-tracking can come at a high political cost. Hence, it is at the public announcement juncture that evidence is sought to validate the policy stance taken. As such, in policymaking, research will rarely be the driving force, but it is often the fuel (Haskins & Baron, 2011; Weiss, 1991).

Politicians know that evidence lends legitimacy to their public action and potentially engenders trust and confidence

from the public. Policymakers primarily use research evidence to support their preexisting beliefs and bolster their messaging or “political mantra” (Horton & Brown, 2018). As such, even when the evidence for their position is weak—politicians will often stick to their position until the tide shifts and they can safely move to the other side of an issue. As a result of this accelerated timeframe, only occasionally can legislators be convinced to make an ideological change/shift as a result of a new insight they gain from the evidence with which they are presented (Weiss, Murphy-Grahan, Petrosino, & Gandhi, 2008).

This targeted use of evidence to support political stances underscores that politics are largely about values (Weiss, 1977); policymaking is not neutral—it requires a political position. As researchers, we can tap into this by identifying the value framework a politician embraces and assessing the extent to which our research fits within it. When we enter the policymaking world in this way, we do face an ethical dilemma: are we willing to eschew the cloak of impartiality that comes with underlying philosophy of science-based research? Is it problematic that many of the decisions to use evidence are driven by efforts to garner support for preexisting ideas that fit a particular political point of view (Finnigan & Daly, 2014; Manna & Petrili, 2008)? We as “experts” and our work as “evidence” will indeed be cherry-picked (Horton & Brown, 2018), but I am not sure this is much different from the fact that when we present our work we mostly highlight other work that supports our findings and minimize work that does not.

Despite challenges associated with timing and the value-laden nature of policymaking, it is hard to think of an educational researcher who does not want their work to be used to solve a pressing or seemingly intractable problem in education. Our failure to make meaningful contributions to policymaking is not for lack of knowledge or expertise on a topic. It may be instead the prospect of navigating an unfamiliar political terrain or discomfort with engaging in advocacy work. The next section of this article provides a navigational framework for educational researchers thinking about ways to infuse their research findings into the federal education policymaking process.

Processes and entry points into the policy world for educational researchers

The view of the American policymaking process from the outside—through public and social media—is disconcerting and, the policy world as a whole can appear alarmingly chaotic. From an “outsider-inside” vantage point, the environment appears as it actually is—dynamic and fast-paced and sometimes unpredictable, but also orderly. The federal policy process has several stages that may recycle back from identifying and defining a problem, to generating, implementing and evaluating a policy to address the problem, and many, many meetings in between. Evidence can potentially influence the policymaking process at each stage, but different types of evidence and different approaches to conveying that evidence may be required. Thus, infusing research into the

policy process is decidedly recursive—it is not a straight line and there is no guarantee that the provision of that evidence will yield a particular policy outcome (Malakoff, 2017). Further, policy work is never an individual endeavor—it involves several stakeholders including members of congress and their staff, committee staff, department officials, leaders from regulatory agencies, but also lobbyists, advocacy groups, scholars from the academy, experts from think-tanks and policy institutes. As such, part of effective engagement in policymaking is getting to know and working strategically with other stakeholders.

A common way of conceptualizing the policymaking process is as a set of six linked stages (see Figure 1) that entail specific activities and stakeholders. The steps are sequentially ordered as follows: (1) identifying and defining the problem, (2) setting an agenda, (3) formulating a policy, (4) legitimizing the policy, (5) implementing the policy, (6) evaluating the policy. This last stage might cycle back to stage one and prompt the elimination or update of an existing policy. My experience suggests that opportunities to infuse evidence into the policymaking process are evident at every stage, but focuses on the first four stages; problem identification, agenda setting and policymaking.

Stage 1: Problem identification and definition

Often precipitated by discontent with the current state of affairs or by an event, this stage is often marked by a sense of urgency. Also, a remarkable feature of the American political process; this as entry point into policymaking is relatively easy. Legislators’ offices are set up to allow ordinary people or “the public” to initiate a conversation with the legislator—often through their staffers—about something important to them. Policymakers are largely motivated by their constituents, who are oftentimes the people to identify a problem that requires policy intervention. Constituents are ordinary citizens, but are also “groups” who represent a part of the congressperson’s constituency, such as representatives from the local community college or the fire-fighters’ league.

Educational researchers can enter this phase of the process as “ordinary” albeit more informed constituents. Key to the whole endeavor at this stage is to capture interest in your research. This first step often occurs at the level of personal-office engagement. Educational researchers should visit and meet with staff in legislative offices, especially legislators in their constituency, those whose priorities are aligned with their research or who serve on key committees. For education issues, these committees would be the House Committee on Education and the Workforce, and the Senate Committee on Health, Education, Labor and Pensions.

Educational researchers can also serve a role as knowledge brokers and empower ordinary citizens with evidence-based knowledge to bolster their efforts to engage the political system. For example, a fellow faculty member/researcher supplied a group of parents in her district with evidence-based knowledge to take to their legislator to help support their case for shifting school times for middle and high school students to later in the day. Also, if you are doing

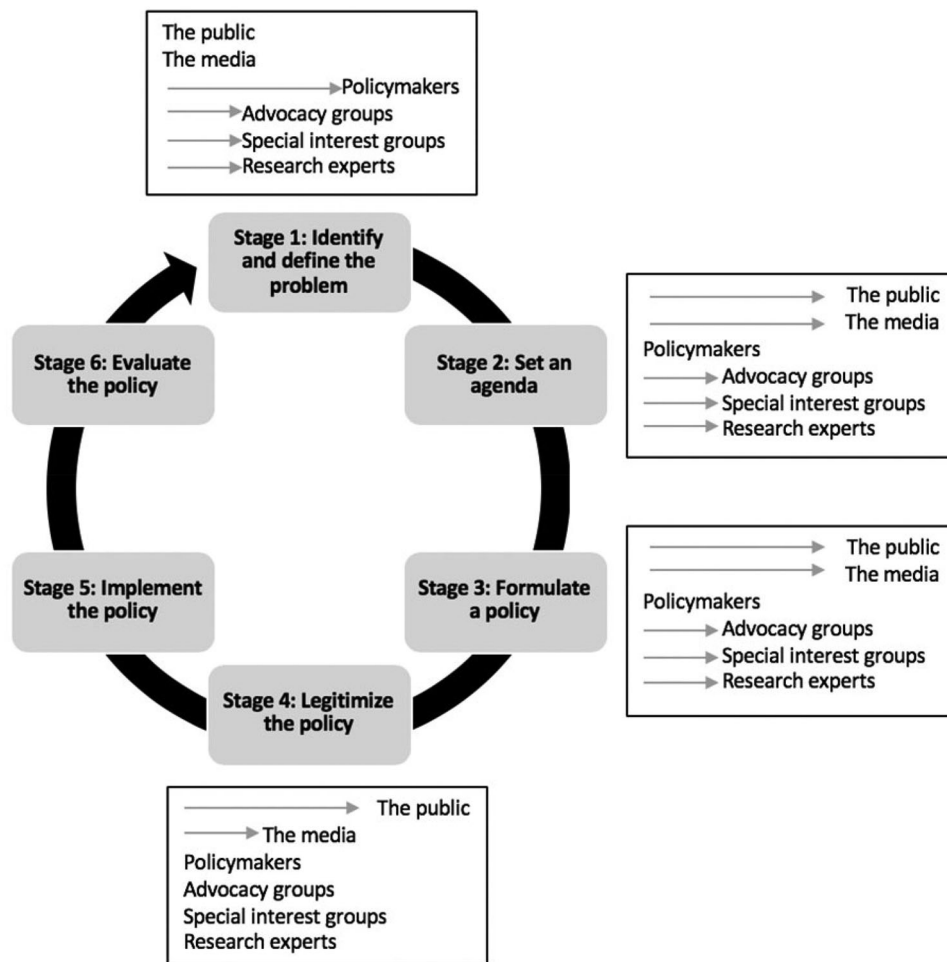


Figure 1. Stage model of the policymaking process and key process-drivers in stages 1–4.

education research in local schools, you can invite the legislator or their staff to that school to see your research in action. Media will invariably get involved, and this will raise general awareness about your work and could prompt a deeper interest in how the work could be harnessed to highlight or address a policy-related issue. You can also engage your legislator by inviting them to give the keynote address at a research conference/event or meeting organized at your institution.

Stage 2: Agenda setting

Before uptake of an idea for policy development or change, it must make it to the agenda—move to a place of active consideration. This is the stage at which researchers can get a clear picture of whether their work resonates or can fit within the legislator’s overarching political framework. At this stage, the policy proposal has to be aligned with the broader political agenda: who is in power, what the main issues are, and what is clearly on the docket for consideration matters a great deal. This is the stage at which it becomes clear how much of policymaking has to do with a stance or a particular set of values. At this juncture, policymakers primarily use research

or evidence to support or bolster a preexisting set of beliefs. Values can and do change over time but only occasionally are policymakers convinced to make a change or shift as a result of a new insight they gain from evidence brought before them. If it happens, it is usually in the context of a major societal event, for example 911.

An important engagement goal for educational researchers at this stage is awareness of the political landscape. Keeping abreast of education issues covered in the daily news (especially through outlets staffers monitor, such as *The Hill*, *Politico*, *Huff Post*, *Wallstreet Journal*) and staying informed about activity at the Department of Education is critically important. Lastly, it helps to pay attention to what the education policy think tanks, groups, and associations are writing about. When and what type of evidence matters a great deal for evidence uptake (Haskins & Margolis, 2014), as such, pay close attention to how these stakeholders frame and discuss relevant research.

Another important goal at this stage is to nurture a relationship with staffers in a legislator’s office, so that you come to mind when staffers need to call on someone when your “issue area” arises. The office one targets to engage can be based on a relationship—“I am a constituent in your district,” or it can be based on value-alignment “I also care and

have expertise to help you move your agenda forward.” Selecting the right venue for engagement should be based on how much attention you can garner on your issue area.

Stage 3: Formulating a policy

At this stage, the problem has been defined and the main task is formulating the policy solution. The process here involves a substantial amount of planning and plotting, as sometimes the goal is to topple an alternative policy idea using evidence. This is often the case when the legislator’s party is not in the majority. Political offices spend a great deal of time determining a strategy—both a legislative one, as well as other strategies to help move the policy solution forward, including messaging strategies, and engagement strategies with outside groups, and importantly—a press and communication strategy.

This is an intense time of data gathering and vetting of evidence, and many people aggressively enter the landscape. While all of these people have in common a specific policy interest, their views may be vastly different and the collating of evidence and achieving buy-in across them is a critical part of the process. As such, the role of researchers in developing policy should not be underestimated, even if they are not at the writing table. It is not uncommon for a congressional committee to holding hearings on a particular bill to hear testimony from academics who have important insights on an issue based on their programmatic line of research. For example, during my time on the Hill, Russell Skiba was invited to give testimony about the disproportionate use of exclusionary discipline practices with African American students. If possible, when issues arise within the scope of their research expertise, educational researchers should attend hearings and consider testifying or writing reaction statements for public consumption.

Capitalizing on current circumstances cannot be underestimated—the window of opportunity to be fully engaged and serve as a resource for research-based evidence is often very narrow. Part of the educational researcher’s goal must entail recognizing political opportunities. One of the most important things is to be aware of major legislation coming up for reauthorization and try to stay ahead of it. Lastly, when researchers get requests, they should respond immediately as the urgency on Capitol Hill is double speed.

Stage 4: Policy legitimization

This stage marks the passage of the law by congress. This is the stage at which “official” law-making begins, defined by a formal set of procedures outlining how the process proceeds from the introduction of a bill to the signing of the bill into law. There are two parallel processes in each of the two chambers of the government: the house and senate. Timing is a critical issue—when a bill is introduced is carefully planned but myriad things might delay or accelerate its introduction. Staffers’ schedules sometimes drastically shift due to breaking news at the national level or within the state/district such that an immediate response is needed,

and everything will shift to accommodate this. All planned activities for the day may come to a halting stop—and “all hands-on-deck” for the issue at hand such that the careful planning for a bill introduction is undone. Also noteworthy on the time front, is that the time it takes for a bill to move through this process will vary greatly. Major legislation, such as the reauthorization of ESSA and HEA may take a full two-year congressional session (or longer), whereas smaller bills may move from start to finish in a single week or just a few weeks.

Your introduction of evidence is more likely to shape policy if it is useful to inform a bill that is actually “moving” or on the docket for consideration. However, your research can also inform “messaging bills”—bills that are not on the docket and not going anywhere—but may at some more opportune time in the future. This might raise the profile of your research and enable you over the course of an atypically long period of time, to fine tune how you share your evidence. Messaging bills will shape policy down the line when the composition of congress changes and the bill has better chances of moving forward through the legislative process. A substantial amount of press coverage occurs around bill introduction so there is also an opportunity for researchers to infuse evidence into the policymaking process by commenting on legislation based on their research findings.

Stage 4 is marked by a lot of negotiation. The role of committees becomes central, and committee staff are actually very amenable to using research findings. Committee staff actively engage experts and at particular junctures, may reach out to gather more information (Weiss, 1989). At both the legislative office and committee levels, a critical role is also played by intermediary organizations or groups, such as *New America*, *American Council on Education (ACE)*, *The Education Trust (EdTrust)*, *American Association for Colleges of Teacher Education (AACTE)*. Above are a few examples, but there are many of these intermediary organizations and they play two primary roles: translation and dissemination. Their work is remarkably tailored and timely. Committee staff engage them in collective action to garner support for particular bills and it is frequently the way they bring issues to a larger audience. Their role in gathering and evaluating evidence can also not be underestimated. They know a great deal about policy issues, and have the wherewithal to collect and analyze data in real time, and have mastered the art of effective communication with staffers. There is something to be said “when the makers of policy are specialized experts in the substance of the policy domain” (Nutley, 2003, p. 14)!

A cautionary note on groups, however, was captured well in the conclusion statement of a recent social science study examining policy statements from organizations concerning the effects of media on youth (Elson et al., 2019): “Thus, it seems that current policy statements tend to be more definitive than is warranted by the underlying science. This may result in a misrepresentation of a research field to policymakers and the general public” (p. 12). The authors suggest that when formulating policy statements, “it is important

that policy statements note the existence of inconsistent data and significant debates or controversies” (p. 21). This recommendation highlights how disconnected we are as researchers from the reality of policymaking and how much of our success in integrating evidence into the process depends on consensus and surety even in the face of great uncertainty about our findings. Policy statements are not and cannot be balanced. They must be pitched just right so that they can garner public support for a bill that supporters would like to get through. Thus, educational researchers’ successful engagement entails letting go of the false notion that research can be integrated into the policy space as impartial and independent of politics. Small comfort to us as scientists who shudder at the prospect. However, if it is any consolation, talking across the political aisle does happen, especially at the committee level and each side brings their evidence to bear—this is where and how balance is achieved. We must accept that if our infusion of evidence into the conversation means we have to put it forward loudly and confidently we cannot include it with caveats, otherwise we run the risk of it not being considered (Gillies, 2014), and rest assured many other voices and often voices that are not evidence-based will prevail.

Problems in translation: Science communication and getting your message across

One of the most important skills you learn on the Hill is the power of “messaging.” You message to yourself, you message to your constituents, you message to your advisors, you message to your boss, you message to the media, you master the art of messaging, and then learn to “pivot” so that you can remain on message. As educational researchers, our challenge is that our messaging is actually science communication, and there are times when our message is lost in translation because of an antipathy in the policy world toward science itself (Horton & Brown, 2018; Schultz, 2017). As such, part of our messaging has to be that scientific research is important. The Alda Center for Communicating Science (n.d.) defines good science communication as the ability to: “communicate complex topics in clear, vivid, and engaging ways; leading to improved understanding by the public, media, patients, elected officials, and others outside of their own discipline.” The best communications are targeted and deeply succinct, the motto on the hill is mastering the art of the “ask” and the one-page handout. Guides exist about how to write policy briefs (ICPA, 2017; Wong, Green, Bazemore, & Miller, 2017), but more helpful than those, if you want your research to be appropriately considered as evidence, is the “legislative policy brief.” These “combine the research syntheses and policy recommendations found in policy briefs with a section drafted by an attorney containing model statutory language. The model statutory language details how legislative bodies can act on the policy recommendations” (National Education Policy Center, 2019).

Researchers are notoriously bad at communicating findings to nonacademic audiences, and often assume their implications are self-evident. The real world of policymaking

involves multiple layers and many people at different levels of readiness to consider research evidence. We, therefore, need to be able to tailor our communications. Especially important on this front, is knowing what and what not to include. A study by Sorian and Baugh (2002) illustrates that less is most certainly more! Results of their survey of close to 300 state government policymakers makes it clear that we overdo it—we provide too much information. They also note that legislators want to know what tools they can use to find research relevant to their policy issue areas.

Lastly, we do our work a great injustice when we give short thrift to the section on policy implications in our manuscripts. Additionally, it helps to read actual legislative text—doing this can vastly improve one’s understanding about what actually constitutes a “policy implication.” If we can get better at understanding the policymaking process, and the details embedded within policy, we can make our research count. Nutley et al. (2002) summarizes well some key considerations in determining whether legislators are apt to pay attention to and take-up particular research evidence. Some considerations are personal: does the policymaker believe in evidence as a means to support expert opinion? Other considerations have to do with the research “fit”: is the evidence clear, relevant, and supportive of the policymaker’s existing ideology? Contextual considerations also matter: is the research timely? Is the evidence derived through relatively uncontested research methods? Are the users of the research partners in generating the evidence? Do the research findings have strong advocates? Also important are considerations regarding implementation: are the results of implementing the policy robust? If needed could we reverse course? These questions illustrate important dynamics inherent in the policymaking arena, and highlight the fact that it is not impossible to adapt our approaches accordingly. Once you have the attention of legislators as a research expert on a particular policy issue—be ready, and respond immediately to any requests. Note again, that the sense of urgency on Capitol Hill is dire—immediately means immediately!

Conclusions

In sum, legislators and staff within the policymaking landscape are open to incorporating science-based research into their endeavors. This is an important role that we as educational researchers can play however, our success is contingent on recognizing the dynamic, political and often urgent tenor of the policymaking process in the United States. Further, we have to adjust the design of our research and communication of research findings to fit within this policymaking milieu if our work is to be useful in policymaking (Nutley et al., 2002). This agenda to engage the policymaking process is not for the faint of heart among us, but there are other ways educational researchers can be meaningfully involved, two are briefly described below.

Congressional and executive branch fellowships are an important entry point into policymaking experience. The potential of programs like the American Association for the

Advancement of Science (AAAS)'s Science and Technology Fellowship is significant, and the American Educational Research Association's sponsorship of educational researchers to participate in this program provides opportunities to engage with policymakers and inform policy decisions on local, state, and national levels. This year-long experience can be transformational (it was for me!) and can fill important gaps in educational researchers' knowledge about and experience with policymaking. In this role, educational researchers are in a position to learn, but also to bring to bear a more data-driven, scientific approach to decision-making in the political arena. I would hope that an outcome of these fellowships is sustained policy engagement by educational researchers, and increased confidence in the utility of research-based evidence among legislators and their staff who worked with the fellows. Some fellows will stay on—move on to the executive branches and make their contributions through setting funding priorities for research to be funded by federal agencies like the Institutes for Education Sciences or the National Science Foundation. Some may stay on Capitol Hill as staffers or policy directors; committees are often a good home because of the long-term vision on policy issues. Other fellows will join think-tanks, policy institutes or advocacy groups, or return to their home states and become more engaged in state-level policymaking, where efforts are much more tailored and specific to local circumstances and the translation of policy-to-practice is more tangible. For those of us who return to the academy, because the fellowship experience entails learning while doing, the experience may translate into a change in perspective about how we structure our research, and also how we train the next generation of educational researchers. We are likely more invested in developing and training students to adopt effective science communication practices, and maintain an awareness and willingness to engage in policymaking.

Other innovative initiatives to more meaningfully engage researchers in policy work are emerging. The Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) for example, has an initiative which entails the formation of a Rapid Assessment and Response Strategy (RARS) Team that coalesces around a topic and engages in a rapid and systematic process to formulate evidence-based responses to policy-relevant issues that emerge. The goal is to increase engagement in public policy issues proactively and rapidly where there is compelling research they can bring to bear in response to a current event. The process engages policy and content experts from researchers who are members of SRCD. Lastly, many professional organizations provide opportunities for faculty to join a delegation of researchers and college administrators to share their work and have a “beginner’s” visit to Capitol Hill for a day. Faculty are provided mini-trainings on how to summarize their work, talk to staffers and familiarize themselves with the policymaking arena in advance of the visit so that they can make the most out of the experience. This can also serve as an “in” with offices.

In sum, whatever the path, the message is that educational researchers can be involved with policymaking, but

the path toward that can vary. Parting and wise advice: “Learn the lingo, and identify the key players. Realize that the path of evidence is winding, and the destination often distant. It’s not unusual for it to take decades for the weight of evidence to leave its mark on policy. But when it does, the results can often be extraordinary...” (Malakoff, 2017, p. 563).

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